

Flipped

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FADE IN:

BLACK.

A sound builds in the dark: applause. Not scattered – total. The kind of applause that has been waiting.

Then a voice, warm and unhurried, belonging to a man who has learned that silence is a gift you give an audience right before you take everything else.

McGEE (V.O.)

I want to start tonight with a question.

The applause fades.

McGEE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

When is the last time someone sat across from you and made you feel like the most important thing in the room?

FADE UP SLOWLY ON:

INT. ARENA - BACKSTAGE CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Fluorescent. Cinder block. The ugly infrastructure beneath a beautiful surface.

DR. BRIAN McGEE (52) moves through the corridor flanked by DEREK (28, his assistant, a man who has learned to think ahead) and a two-person SECURITY DETAIL.

Open collar. Good watch. Nothing that reads as wealth until you look twice – which is the point.

The roar of the crowd pushes through the walls. Twelve thousand seats. All of them full.

McGEE

(walking, not looking at Derek)

Overflow?

DEREK

Two auxiliary rooms. Screens.
Another four thousand.

McGee nods. Sixteen thousand people who drove here,
flew here, took days off work, paid two hundred dollars
for a seat. To be in the same room as this man.

DEREK (CONT'D)

The journalist is already on stage.
She wants fifteen minutes before
you come out.

McGEE

She gets ten.

He stops at a mirror on the cinder block wall. Looks
at himself. Adjusts nothing. Walks away.

The mirror holds his reflection a beat after he's gone.

CUT TO:

INT. ARENA - STAGE - NIGHT

The stage is minimal. Two chairs angled toward each other
under a single wide wash of light. Behind them, projected
twenty feet high: the cover of a book.

THE UNBROKEN SELF

Dr. Brian McGee

The auditorium is full. Not a concert crowd – something
more serious. People who came because they needed to.
Couples. Solitary people. People who have been crying
before the event started.

In the eighth row, center: CAROL WHITMORE (47). She
holds a copy of the book – already worn, already marked
up – against her chest. Her face is open in the way
faces get when they've been hurting long enough that

hope feels dangerous.

On stage, SARAH VANCE (41, journalist, New Yorker profile writer, a woman who has interviewed everyone and is not easily impressed) sits in one chair, reviewing her notes.

A PRODUCTION ASSISTANT counts down. Five. Four. Three.

The crowd begins to stir.

McGEE enters from stage left.

The applause is immediate and enormous.

He holds up one hand – please – and they settle, though not all the way. He sits across from Sarah Vance. Leans back. Comfortable. The way you're comfortable in your own kitchen.

McGEE
Thank you.

(to the crowd, simply)

Thank you for being here.

SARAH VANCE
Dr. McGee. The Unbroken Self.
You've
described this as the most personal
thing you've written. In what
sense?

McGEE
In the sense that every previous book
was a framework. A system. This one is
a confession.

He opens his hands.

McGEE (CONT'D)
I spent twenty years telling people
that healing was possible. And then

I spent five years asking myself
whether I believed that.

SARAH VANCE

Do you?

McGEE

I believe in the work. I believe in
the conversation. Whether that constitutes
healing –

(a small smile)

– I leave to the reader.

In the eighth row, Carol writes something in the margin
of her copy.

SARAH VANCE

The book opens with a line I want
to
read back to you.

She finds the page.

SARAH VANCE (CONT'D)

"The greatest damage done to the
human mind is not trauma. It is the
story we build around the trauma to
make it bearable. I am in the
business of dismantling that
story."

She looks up.

SARAH VANCE (CONT'D)

That's a significant claim.

McGEE

It's an honest one.

SARAH VANCE
Dismantling someone's story – their
framework for surviving – sounds
destabilizing. Dangerous, even.

McGEE
All real change is destabilizing.

(to the room now, not just to her)

You don't renovate a house without
tearing something down first.

The audience responds. Murmurs of recognition. Nodding.
Carol is nodding.

McGEE (CONT'D)
The question is whether you have
someone beside you who knows what
they're doing when they swing
the hammer.

A beat.

McGEE (CONT'D)
That's what I offer.

In the front row: a WOMAN begins to cry. Silently.
She doesn't seem embarrassed. She seems relieved.

SARAH VANCE
Critics of your method –

McGEE
There are always critics.

SARAH VANCE
– have argued that what you call
"dismantling the story" is, in
practice,
a process of making people
dependent
on you and your framework. That the

goal is not to liberate patients
but to replace one story with
another
story – yours.

A silence. The audience waits.

McGee considers her.

McGEE
That's a sophisticated argument.

SARAH VANCE
Is it wrong?

McGEE
It would require me to be more
interested in my patients' attachment
to me than in their actual progress.

He looks at the audience.

McGEE (CONT'D)
Everyone in this room who has done
work with me, or with my practitioners,
or through the podcast – I want you
to ask yourself something.

The room is absolutely still.

McGEE (CONT'D)
Do you feel more yourself than when
you started? Or less?

A beat. Then applause – not all of it, but most of it.
Organic, genuine. Carol is clapping.

SARAH VANCE
(pressing)
Some former patients have said
the opposite. That they felt –

McGEE

Some patients leave in the middle of
a surgery and say the surgeon hurt them.

(gently, before it lands too hard)

I'm not dismissing those experiences.
I'm saying that the process of
genuine change is uncomfortable.
And discomfort can be misread.

SARAH VANCE
Or it can be discomfort.

McGEE

(a real smile – she's good)

Yes. It can be.

He leans forward. His voice drops, just slightly – the
move that draws a crowd of thousands into a room of two.

McGEE (CONT'D)

I am not perfect. The work is not
perfect. What I can tell you is that
I have sat across from thousands of
people in tremendous pain, and I have
not looked away once.

Silence. Then the woman in the front row starts clapping
again and it spreads and it becomes the standing ovation
that was waiting.

McGee lets it build. He doesn't milk it. He simply
receives it, with the particular grace of a man who
has learned that modesty, performed correctly, is
more powerful than pride.

When it settles, Sarah Vance glances at her notes.
One last question.

SARAH VANCE
Last question. And I'd ask you to
answer it simply, if you can.

McGEE
I'll do my best.

SARAH VANCE
Dr. McGee —

(a beat)

Do you actually help people?

The room is still.

McGee looks at her.

A long beat. Then:

GLITCH.

The image stutters — a frame skip, a half-second of visual static, something wrong in the signal.

McGEE
No.

Simple. Quiet. Almost relieved.

BACK.

The image snaps clean. McGee is smiling.

McGEE (CONT'D)
Help is a loaded word. What I do is
create conditions. What people do
within those conditions — that's theirs.

Sarah Vance studies him for a moment.

SARAH VANCE
(to the audience)
The Unbroken Self is available
tonight. Dr. Brian McGee.

The applause returns. Final and enormous.

McGee stands. Turns to the crowd. Raises one hand – not a wave. An acknowledgment. I see you.

The camera finds Carol in the eighth row. On her feet like everyone else. Holding her book to her chest. Eyes wet.

She has just decided something. We can see it on her face.

The decision will cost her everything.

SMASH CUT TO BLACK.

TITLE CARD:

FLIPPED

BLACK.

Then:

TITLE CARD: SIX MONTHS LATER

CUT TO:

INT. MCGEE'S OFFICE - DAY

SESSION: CAROL WHITMORE - MONTH ONE

The office is engineered to feel like safety.

Warm amber light. No overhead fluorescents. Furniture chosen to suggest intimacy without clinical coldness – a deep couch, a low table, two chairs angled toward each other rather than facing like a confrontation. A white noise machine hums softly outside the door.

There are no diplomas on the wall.

Carol Whitmore (47) sits across from McGee with a tissue

in her hand she isn't using. Her posture is the posture of a woman who has held herself together for a long time and is very tired of it.

She is wearing the same sweater she wore to the book launch. The small embroidered bird. She brought the book. It is in her bag.

CAROL

My daughter thinks this is a
mistake.
Coming to you.

McGEE

Tell me why she thinks that.

CAROL

She read something online. Some
forum.
She said –

(a small laugh)

She said you're a cult.

McGEE

(smiling)

What do you think?

CAROL

I think I haven't slept through the
night in four years and I'm willing
to try anything.

McGEE

That's not a small thing to say.

CAROL

No. I guess it isn't.

He looks at her for a long moment. Unhurried. Present.

McGEE

I want you to know something, Carol.
From our very first session. Whatever
we do here – however long it takes –
I am not going anywhere.

She looks at him.

McGEE (CONT'D)

I am not going to get tired of you.
I am not going to give up. I am not
going to decide you're too much.

Her eyes fill.

McGEE (CONT'D)

You are not too much.

Carol Whitmore begins to cry – not performing it,
not managing it. Just crying, in this warm light,
in front of this man who just said the exact thing
no one has said to her in a very long time.

He hands her the tissue box. She takes one.

What we see: a moment of genuine human connection.
A woman beginning to feel safe.

What we will later understand: this promise – *I am not
going anywhere* – is one McGee has made to seventy-two
other patients. He keeps all of them.

That is the system.

CUT TO:

INT. MCGEE'S OFFICE - DAY

SESSION: PATIENT ONE – THOMAS

A different quiet. Softer, more weighted.

THOMAS (44, construction foreman, hands that have built things and now don't know what to do with themselves) sits with his arms on his knees, looking at the floor. He has been crying recently. Not now. Recently.

McGEE

Tell me about the sound.

THOMAS

It's like – I can't describe it.
Metal and something else. Something
I didn't want to know was in there.

A long pause.

THOMAS (CONT'D)

I was driving.

McGEE

Yes.

THOMAS

I wasn't – it wasn't my fault.
The police said –

McGEE

I know what the police said.

He leans in.

McGEE (CONT'D)

What do you say?

Thomas looks up. This specific gentleness – this move – is what makes people feel found by McGee. He doesn't offer comfort. He offers witness. It is more addictive than comfort.

THOMAS

I should have seen him.

McGEE

(quietly)

Yes.

Not agreement. Not absolution. Acknowledgment.
And somehow that is more powerful than either.

Thomas exhales.

McGEE (CONT'D)

Let's sit with that.

They do.

What the audience sees: a gifted man meeting another
man in his pain.

What we will later understand: McGee has identified the
word should and filed it. He will return to it.
He always does.

CUT TO:

INT. MCGEE'S OFFICE - DAY

SESSION: PATIENT TWO — RENATA

RENATA (31, graduate student, very thin in the particular
way people become when anxiety is the primary caloric
expense) sits on the couch with her shoes off. Comfortable
here. Too comfortable — the comfort of a place you've
been too many times.

Session Thirty-One.

RENATA

Brian, I've been thinking about
what
you said last week. About the
"protective architecture."

McGEE

And?

RENATA

I can see it so clearly now. How
nobody
was ever actually allowed in. Even
—

She stops. Puts her hand over her mouth.

RENATA (CONT'D)

Even Marcus.

Marcus was her fiancé. He left eight months ago.
Two months after she started seeing McGee.

McGEE

Even Marcus.

RENATA

He couldn't handle the process.
You said some people in our lives
aren't equipped to be with us when
we're changing.

McGEE

I said people who are invested in
our stasis sometimes struggle when
we begin to move.

RENATA

Right. Right.

She nods. She has heard this many times. It has become
belief the way a thing heard often enough becomes belief.

What the audience sees: a patient finding language for
her experience.

What we see: Renata is using McGee's language to describe
the erosion of every relationship she had before him.
She is not growing. She is being cleared.

CUT TO:

INT. MCGEE'S OFFICE - DAY

SESSION: CAROL WHITMORE - MONTH SEVEN

Same office. Different Carol.

She is here twice a week now. Has been since month four. Something in her has become smaller – not in an obvious way. In the way a thing becomes smaller when its center has been replaced with something else.

CAROL

I called Denise.

Her daughter.

McGEE

When?

CAROL

Last week. I just – I called her.
She came over. We had dinner.
She cooked.

(a pause)

It was good, Brian. Normal good.
Like before. I wasn't thinking about
the process. I was just eating.

A silence. McGee looks at her.

McGEE

And that felt –?

CAROL

Like something I hadn't felt in a
while.

McGEE

(carefully)

Tell me something. In that dinner –
did you talk about the work you've
been doing here?

CAROL

She asked. I said I was doing well.

McGEE

You didn't tell her about the intensive?

CAROL

She would have made it a whole
thing.

McGEE

So you protected the relationship
by concealing part of yourself.

CAROL

(something shifts)

I – what?

McGEE

I'm not criticizing. I'm observing.
The work we've done here has taught
you to protect your process from
external interference. That's growth.

CAROL

But I wasn't protecting the
process.
I was just having dinner.

McGEE

Were you though?

She stares at him.

McGEE (CONT'D)

Your first instinct – when she asked –

was to conceal. That instinct exists for a reason. It exists because this room is safe.

He gestures toward the window.

McGEE (CONT'D)

Out there, people are invested in your stasis. Even the people who love you. Especially them.

CAROL

(very quietly)

That's not – I don't think that's what happened.

McGEE

What do you think happened?

A long silence. She is trying to hold onto the dinner. The easy feeling. Her daughter's laugh.

All of it is being slowly reclassified as threat.

CAROL

(her voice breaking)

I think I just wanted one night that was normal.

McGEE

(so gently)

Of course you did. That longing is completely understandable.

(beat)

And it's also information. About where you still are in the process.

She begins to cry. Not the soft tears of month one. Something harder, from a place she didn't know was there.

He hands her the tissue box.

He watches her cry with the focus of a man reading data.

CUT TO:

INT. COMMUNITY CENTER - EVENING

A support group. Ten chairs, nine occupied. All McGee's patients – various ages, various wounds – speaking with the particular fluency of people given a shared vocabulary.

NADIA OSEI (34) sits among them for the second time. Still. Watching. She takes up exactly the space she intends to and no more.

Carol is speaking.

CAROL

I've been having these thoughts. At night mostly. Really dark ones.

NADIA

What kind of thoughts?

The group looks at her. Nadia doesn't usually speak.

CAROL

Brian says they're part of the process.
The darkness is just the old self resisting.

NADIA

What do they feel like to you?
Outside of what Brian says.

A beat. Carol tries to locate the distinction.

CAROL

(quietly)
Scary.

NADIA
You said scary first.

A flicker – brief, like a gap between clouds – where
Carol inhabits herself rather than the framework.

Then the clouds close.

CAROL
I trust the process.

She says it the way people say amen.

Nadia writes in her notebook. One word. Underlined twice.

CLOSE ON: IDEATION.

CUT TO:

INT. MCGEE'S OFFICE - DAY

SESSION: NADIA OSEI - SESSION THREE

Nadia sits across from McGee, coat still on. Her notebook
is in her lap.

McGee has been running his intake technique – the deep
reading, the precise reflection of her own words back
to her, the moves that make people feel found. She has
been letting him.

She is not a normal patient. McGee doesn't know this yet.

McGEE
You mentioned Marcus called you
the week before. And you didn't
call back right away.

NADIA
I was busy. I called him three days
later.

McGEE
Mm.

NADIA
What?

McGEE
Nothing. I'm just –

(settling back)

What does it feel like, when you say that?

NADIA
What does what feel like?

McGEE
"I was busy."

A beat.

Nadia's expression doesn't change. But something behind her eyes does. She is watching him with sudden, total attention – the way you watch something when you realize you've been looking at it wrong.

She reaches for her notebook. Writes something.

McGEE (CONT'D)
(noticing nothing)
Take your time.

NADIA
(without looking up)
Can we go back? You were asking about the call.

McGEE
We can go wherever you need to go.

She looks up. Gives him just enough – just the weight in her eyes he needs to believe the reframe is landing.

NADIA
I think you're right. I think
"busy"
is a word I use when I mean
something else.

McGee nods. Gently. Encouragingly.

He doesn't see her write one more word in the notebook.

CLOSE ON: TECHNIQUE. PHASE 2.

CUT TO:

INT. HOSPITAL CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Nadia stands in a hallway smelling of antiseptic and recycled air. She holds her phone with both hands.

A NURSE passes. Nadia stops her.

NADIA
Carol Whitmore. She was admitted
this evening –

NURSE
Are you family?

NADIA
No. I'm a friend.

NURSE
I'm sorry. Family only.

The nurse moves on. Nadia doesn't.

She stands there for a long time. Then opens her phone.
Presses record. Holds it to her mouth.

NADIA
 (recording)
 Carol Whitmore. Admitted tonight.
 Eleven months in the intensive.
 She tried to tell him it was
 working.
 He told her it was resistance.

She stops recording.

NADIA (CONT'D)
 (quietly, to no one)
 I should have moved faster.

Through the glass of a passing room: Carol – asleep,
 a monitor blinking. Her daughter DENISE (28) sits
 beside her holding her hand.

Nadia doesn't stop. She can't help here now.

CUT TO:

INT. COFFEE SHOP - DAY

Nadia and Carol. Two coffees. A corner table.

Carol is out of the hospital. She looks smaller and
 also somehow more present – as if the framework has
 cracked just enough to let her back in.

NADIA
 How are you feeling?

CAROL
 Strange. Denise keeps asking me
 what I want for dinner.

(a small laugh)

I forgot I had opinions about that.

Nadia looks at her.

NADIA
Carol. Can I ask you something?

CAROL
You're going to ask me to record something. Aren't you.

A beat.

NADIA
Yes.

CAROL
(a long pause)
What would you do with it?

NADIA
I don't know exactly. But I want to have it. In case there's a moment where it matters.

Carol wraps her hands around her coffee cup. Looks out the window. A mother and child pass on the sidewalk.

CAROL
He helped a lot of people. I believe that.
Even now. I believe that.

NADIA
I know you do.

CAROL
It's not like it was all bad.

NADIA
I know that too.

Carol turns back.

CAROL
(quietly)
But the dinner.

NADIA
Tell me about the dinner.

CAROL
He took it. I had one good night
and he took it and turned it into
evidence that I was broken.

(a beat)

And I let him.

She says this like a woman who has just named a thing
that has been living in her without a name.

Nadia puts her phone on the table.

CAROL (CONT'D)
Okay.

CUT TO:

INT. MCGEE'S OFFICE - DAY

SESSION SIX — NADIA

This is the last one.

Both of them know it. The air in the room has a different
quality — charged, like weather.

McGee watches Nadia the way a chess player watches a
board in the middle game.

NADIA

How are you?

She never asks this. He notes it.

McGEE

Fine. You?

NADIA

Clear.

McGEE

Clear is interesting. Tell me about clear.

NADIA

Like the noise gets quieter and you
can hear what's actually there.

McGEE

(nodding)

That's the work.

NADIA

Can I try something? A thought
experiment.

McGEE

Of course.

NADIA

Imagine a therapist. Brilliant.
Genuinely
skilled – the real deal. He can
read
people faster than almost anyone.
He knows, within twenty minutes,
exactly where the wound is.

McGee is very still.

NADIA (CONT'D)

And imagine that skill becomes the method. Not helping patients close the wound – keeping it accessible. Keeping them in the room.

McGEE

This sounds like a projection exercise.

NADIA

Humor me.

A beat.

McGEE

What's the question?

NADIA

Does that therapist know what he's doing?

McGee looks at her. A long, careful moment.

McGEE

I think a person like that would have found a way to believe that what they're doing is serving the patient.

NADIA

Serving the patient. Or serving the process?

McGEE

In his mind, they're the same thing.

NADIA

And the patients who get worse?

McGEE

(a slight edge)

Resistance is part of any genuine process.

NADIA

Even when the resistance looks like
someone losing the will to be
alive?

Silence.

McGEE

What are you actually asking me, Nadia?

She looks at him. And then she does something that
surprises him – she agrees.

NADIA

You're right. I'm dancing around
it.

She reaches into her bag. Sets her phone on the table.
Sets a small recorder next to it. Old, analog.
And then a photograph – printed. Carol in a hospital
bed. Denise at her side.

McGee looks at the photograph for a long time.

McGEE

(quietly)

Where did you get this?

NADIA

Denise sent it.

Beat.

NADIA (CONT'D)

Carol's okay. She's out. She's with
her daughter. She's not coming back
here.

McGEE

(measured)

I'm glad she's –

NADIA
I know what you want.

He stops.

NADIA (CONT'D)
I know the intake metric you use to
prioritize isolated patients. I
know
the six phases. I know what
"intensive
care" actually means in your
system.

She lifts the recorder.

NADIA (CONT'D)
I have Carol on this. Eleven
months,
in her own words.

McGEE
That recording isn't admissible —

NADIA
I know. I'm not going to court.

McGEE
Then what are you doing?

NADIA
Finishing a session.

She stands. Gets her coat.

McGEE
Nadia. Whatever you think you've
uncovered — there is no version of
this where you win. You have one
recording of a grief-compromised
patient. I have forty-three million

listeners and a legal team that does nothing else.

NADIA
(turning back)
I know.

She buttons her coat.

NADIA (CONT'D)
I also know you're going to spend the next week deciding what to do about me. And while you do that, Carol is going to spend that week talking to Denise. And Denise is going to talk to the journalist who interviewed you at the book launch.

McGee says nothing.

NADIA (CONT'D)
She's been looking for a follow-up.

She picks up the recorder and the photograph.
Leaves the phone on the table.

NADIA (CONT'D)
(at the door)
The recording is a copy.

She walks out.

The door closes.

CUT TO:

INT. MCGEE'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

McGee sits.

The phone on the table. Left there deliberately – she wanted him to know she saw it.

He looks at the chair she sat in. The chair Thomas sat in. The chair Renata sat in. The chair Carol sat in, twice a week, for eleven months.

His face does something rare.

Not fear. Not remorse. Something quieter.

Recognition. The brief, unfamiliar experience of being seen – and not being able to perform his way out of it.

Five seconds.

Then it's gone.

He picks up his phone. Dials.

McGEE
Clear my week. Get me Richard.

(beat)

The lawyer.

He goes to the window. Looks out.

The machine is already running.

FADE TO BLACK.

TITLE CARD: FLIPPED

BLACK.

One by one, in silence:

TITLE CARD:

The book launch sold out in eleven minutes.

TITLE CARD:

*Dr. Brian McGee's podcast reached 44 million
listeners the week of publication.*

TITLE CARD:

*The journalist published a follow-up six weeks later.
It was the most-read piece in the magazine's history.*

TITLE CARD:

*McGee's legal team issued a cease and desist
within 48 hours of publication.*

TITLE CARD:

Carol Whitmore did not return to the practice.

TITLE CARD:

Renata still does.

TITLE CARD:

*There is no licensing board for
"Integrative Reality Therapy."*

TITLE CARD:

It is not a recognized clinical method.

TITLE CARD:

*Dr. Brian McGee's waiting list
currently has a four-month lead time.*

FADE OUT.

THE END